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GRAPHIC: A DEATH WRAPPED IN MYSTERY *PG 16*



A NECESSARY RESET US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar in New Delhi, May 24

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▶ INDIA-US TIES

THE RUBIO REPAIR MISSION

The US Secretary of State brought warmth, reassurance and a touch of Trump theatre to a strained partnership, but tensions over China, Pakistan, trade tariffs and migration remain far from resolved

By RAJ CHENGAPPA

WHEN US SECRETARY OF STATE MARCO RUBIO ARRIVED IN INDIA for his first official visit, Washington clearly intended it to be a re-set moment. It needed one, as Indo-US relations had drifted into an uncomfortable limbo in the past year despite the new US ambassador Sergio Gor's efforts to inject vitality into ties by putting key outstanding issues on a bullet-train track. Mostly because US president Donald Trump was preoccupied. When not mired in the Middle East crisis, he was building bridges with Chinese president Xi Jinping—or leaning on Pakistan for diplomatic access to Iran. The perception, as a former Indian diplomat put it, was that America was "sleeping with our enemies and the trust had worn thin".

Meanwhile, trade talks were stuck in the fog of a tariff confusion after India had spent months securing a framework for an interim trade agreement, only to see the US Supreme Court recently upturn all of Trump's tariff policies. Apart from geopolitics and trade, the third pillar that gave ballast to Indo-US relations—people-to-